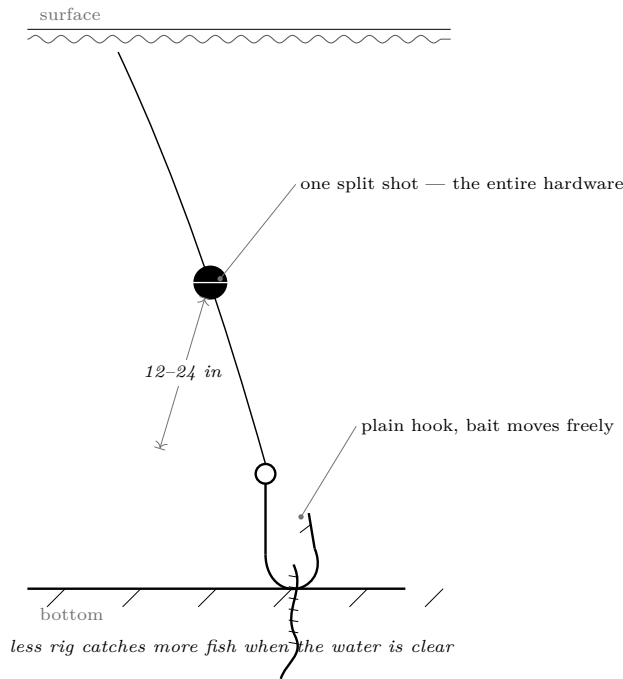


Split Shot Rig

A hook, a pinch of lead, and nothing else

The least rig you can get away with — and often the best



What it does	One small weight pinched on the line 12-24 in above a plain hook. It gives just enough weight to cast and to sink, and leaves the bait free to move naturally.
Why it matters	Every other rig on these sheets adds hardware, and hardware adds unnatural motion. When fish are wary, less rig catches more fish.
Components	A hook. A split shot. That is all.
Shot size	BB or size 5 for panfish; size 3 or larger, or two shot, for bass and smallmouth in deeper water.
Removable shot	Buy the kind with wings on the back so you can reopen and reposition them. You will move the shot constantly.
Catches	Everything. Rock bass, perch, bluegill, smallmouth on a live crayfish, walleye on a leech.

Fish it

1. Pinch one shot on the line, using pliers or your teeth — but never on fluorocarbon leader you care about, because crimping weakens it at that point.
2. Cast out and let it sink on a semi-tight line, watching where the line enters the water.
3. Retrieve in slow, small pulls with long pauses, or simply let it sit on the bottom and wait.
4. Move the shot to change how the bait behaves: closer to the hook makes it sink faster and act tighter, further away lets it drift and swim more freely.

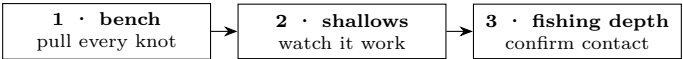
Where it beats a better rig

Wary fish	Pine Lake in flat calm. A single small shot is less unnatural than a jig head or a bullet weight.
Live crayfish	Hook one through the tail with a plain hook and one shot, and drift it across gravel at Pine spots 2, 3 or 4 . Very few smallmouth refuse it.
Teaching	Two components and no rigging. A child can build it in twenty seconds and understand what every part does.
Repair	When you snap off the fancy rig in a rock pile and the light is going, this is the rig you can retie in the dark.
Not for	Heavy weed — the exposed hook fouls. Use a <i>see the Texas rig sheet</i> there instead.

When to use it

Whenever you catch yourself adding hardware to solve a problem that is actually caused by hardware. Start every unfamiliar spot with a split shot and a piece of live bait: it tells you what lives there before you commit to a technique.

Prove the rig



Bench test	Pull the hook knot and pinch the shot only enough to hold; tug it against a ruler mark to prove it does not slide.
Water test	Drop beside the boat: bait should sink slowly ahead of slack line, not spiral.
Proof at depth	You can still feel occasional bottom contact without the bait pinning there.
If it fails	Shot slides: replace it rather than crushing line harder. Bait spins: hook it straighter. Too fast: use a smaller shot or move it farther from the hook. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

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